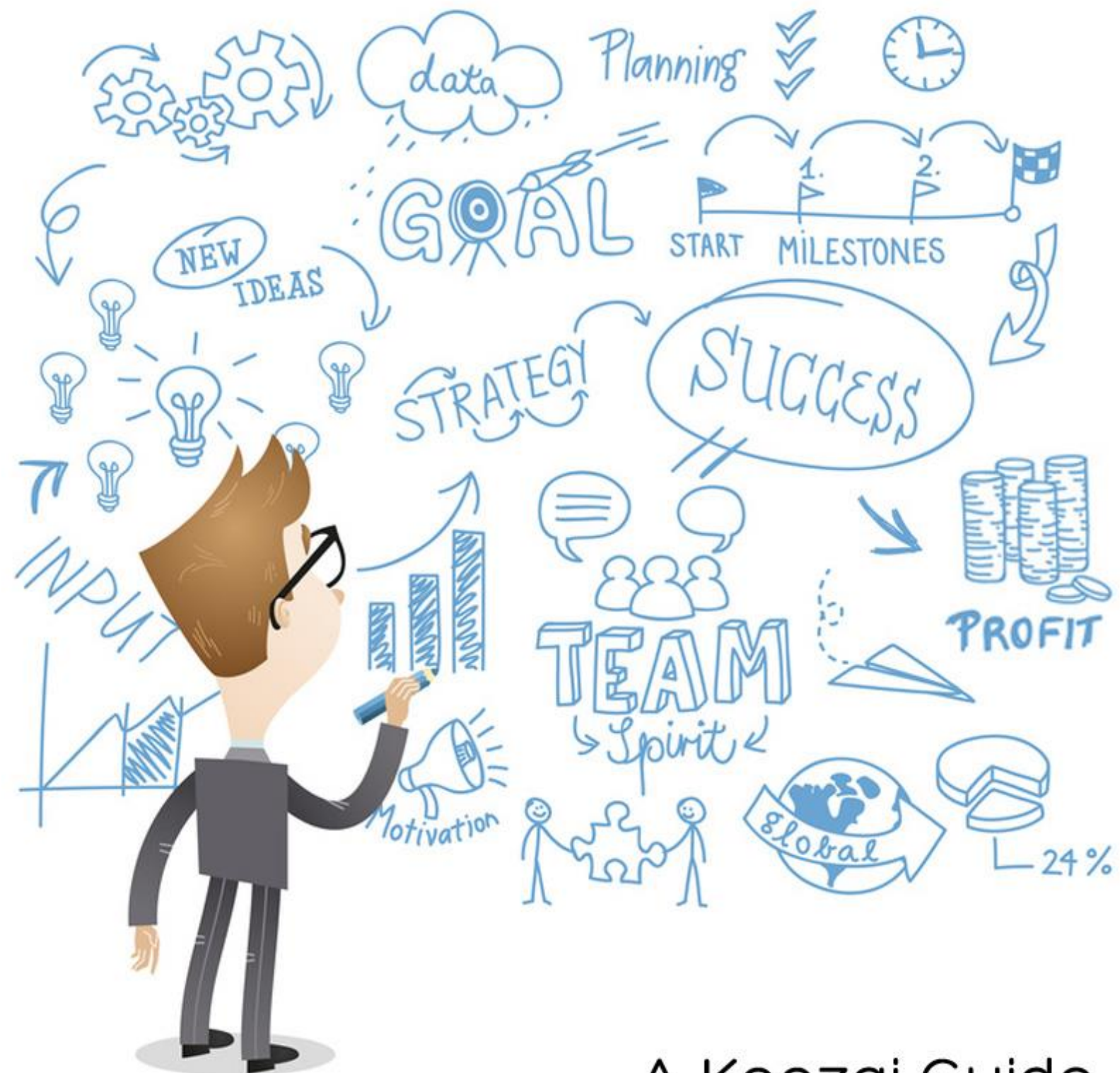


The Complete Guide To: Content Marketing Strategy, Planning and Creation



A Koozai Guide

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A Little Bit About Koozai:

Koozai are a multi-award winning digital marketing agency.

We're one of the UK's fastest growing technology companies having been ranked 23rd in the Deloitte Technology Fast50.

We help businesses connect with their customers online – providing a range of industry-leading services from Organic Search Engine Optimisation (SEO) and Pay Per Click (PPC) Management to Content Marketing, Analytics, Social Media and Brand Management.

We thrive on building long-lasting client relationships and delivering true value for money. We're passionate about what we do - and that shows in our work.

No lengthy contracts, just world class Digital Marketing. Koozai will help you build your brand online and achieve ROI that can be clearly measured against your bottom line.



How To Get In Touch:

If you would like to get in touch with us, please visit our website (www.koozai.com) or use one of the methods below:



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He has also spoken at SMX London, Thinkvis, OMN, Distilled Live, On The Edge and ionSearch.



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With a background in sport media and broadcast journalism, James has the experience, skills and passion to create and oversee truly outstanding content.

Additional content by John Waghorn and Harry Gardiner.

What is Content Marketing?

Content Marketing is not a new concept, especially not in the context of online marketing. People have been writing content since the dawn of time and trying to find ways to reach people with that content, since pen was first put to paper. Every writer wants their work to be found and every marketer wants great content. If there's been a modern shift it's purely that the two forces are working together in greater numbers than ever before.

Content Marketing isn't new to SEO either, often referred to as "Article Marketing" there has always been a drive to produce content for Search Engine Optimisation. However, what changed was a move away from creating a large quantity of content placed on many sites, to creating less content that is stronger and has more chance of attracting links and social shares. Less is more, as the saying goes.

This whitepaper moves away from the old way of thinking with a complete guide to how future Content Marketing works and can flourish. Before then we must first look back at the reasons for the shift, and one of the biggest factors was the Panda update.

The Effect of the Panda Update

Originally dubbed the "Farmer update" by the SEO industry, the Panda update was designed to punish low quality content. It earned the nickname purely because of the massive negative impact it had on content farms (sites that employed freelance writers and generated large amounts of poor quality content) and article marketing websites (sites that allowed anyone to post content on any topic).

Much was made of how these articles did not comply with Google's guidelines and it was no secret that in SEO circles these sites were being spammed with low quality content in an attempt to gain a quick link back to a website. In the initial days post Panda, [Sistrix](#) listed 25 sites that were hit as the image below identifies:

#	Domain	Change	SISTRIX (before)	SISTRIX (after)	# KWs (before)	# KWs (after)
1	wisegeek.com	-77%	121,58	28,22	74.024	21.940
2	ezinearticles.com	-90%	65,08	6,65	184.508	54.277
3	suite101.com	-94%	54,04	3,28	178.373	36.904
4	hubpages.com	-87%	55,16	7,40	152.998	50.178
5	buzzle.com	-85%	43,25	6,55	86.472	24.423
6	associatedcontent.com	-93%	38,29	2,57	216.429	53.512
7	freedownloadscenter.com	-90%	30,26	3,01	42.486	7.992
8	essortment.com	-91%	25,73	2,32	27.501	7.459
9	fixya.com	-80%	28,78	5,83	62.034	36.167
10	americantowns.com	-91%	24,88	2,18	26.000	9.799
11	lovetoknow.com	-83%	25,75	4,28	49.544	17.833
12	articlesbase.com	-94%	19,96	1,16	82.274	31.365



Notably, article marketing sites like ezinearticles, suite101, hubpages and articlesbase were all hit substantially. For example, ezinearticles lost rankings for approximately 130,000 keywords, displaying a percentage change of 90%. For any site, that's a substantial loss, and ezine responded by improving their own standards on all of the articles they received. This was the whole point of Panda – ensuring content is well written, and of a quality standard.

This drastically changed the landscape for Content Marketing in SEO circles and wider online marketing disciplines in a massively positive way. No longer were writers forced to churn out low quality pieces one after the other, instead they were given a single goal; create great content.

Of course that's easier said than done. As an industry we constantly say "we need great content" but how can you get there? By the end of this whitepaper you will have the answers.

Content Types

When it comes to creating content, your only constraint is your own imagination. Whilst you may encounter budget and time constraints, even the smallest campaign can still create outstanding content.

As brands become publishers, there's a great deal of content that any company can create. The type of content really depends on your needs, your business goals, your audience, and your available resources. A lot of this will be defined during your content audit (more on this later). With this in mind, there's a whole host of content types that can be created.

Text Content Types

Blog Posts

When it comes to Content Marketing, the first port of call for any website is a business blog. The content you create on your own site is a great way to add value, as well as generate traffic, social shares and a natural link profile. In its purest form a blog post would be text based with a small amount of images on a single topic, although as the below examples indicate there are many more options you can cover.

Guest Posts

To help grow your profile and that of your business you can create content for relevant industry related sites. Outreaching to and writing for good quality sites in your niche is a great way of building up a high quality link profile, as well as driving referral traffic. We cover some of the things to look out for later in this whitepaper.

PR Mentions And Quotations

If you or your client is looking to build up authority, then being quoted in relevant industry magazines, sites and resources will help ten-fold. It's also a great way to build awareness, as well as create highly relevant links and drive referral traffic. The key is finding journalists who need someone to help with a specific story. Services to use include Gorkana PR, Help A Reporter Out (HARO) as well as using the #journorequest on Twitter.

Ben Norman, managing director of digital marketing agency Koozai, says customers "are now looking for the best-in-class product or service, rather than using a company that has been around the longest".

In this example we were quoted by the BBC

Blogger Reviews

If your business has products you'd like to promote and market, then why not outreach to established relevant bloggers and ask them to review your product(s)? It's an excellent way of gaining online exposure amongst a relevant audience, building a community and generating mentions of your site and brand. One thing to watch out for is that legally, a reviewed product must be declared in the post (more information can be [found here](#)).

Whitepapers And User Guides

If your audience or your client's audience would benefit from a deeper understanding of a particular topic, product or service, then look to create a whitepaper or user guide around that need. Resources that users can easily obtain and download are a superb way to add value to their experience, turning them into loyal users and keeping them coming back for more. They can also be highly useful to understand who reads your content, if you couple them with a form of data collection.



We try to cover some of the key topics in our industry in free whitepapers (like this one!)

Press Releases

If your business has some exciting news to share, this could work really well as a Press Release. There are paid distribution services that can ensure your release is delivered to the most relevant media outlets, so as long as your news is exciting and worthy of being featured, it's well worth creating a press release.

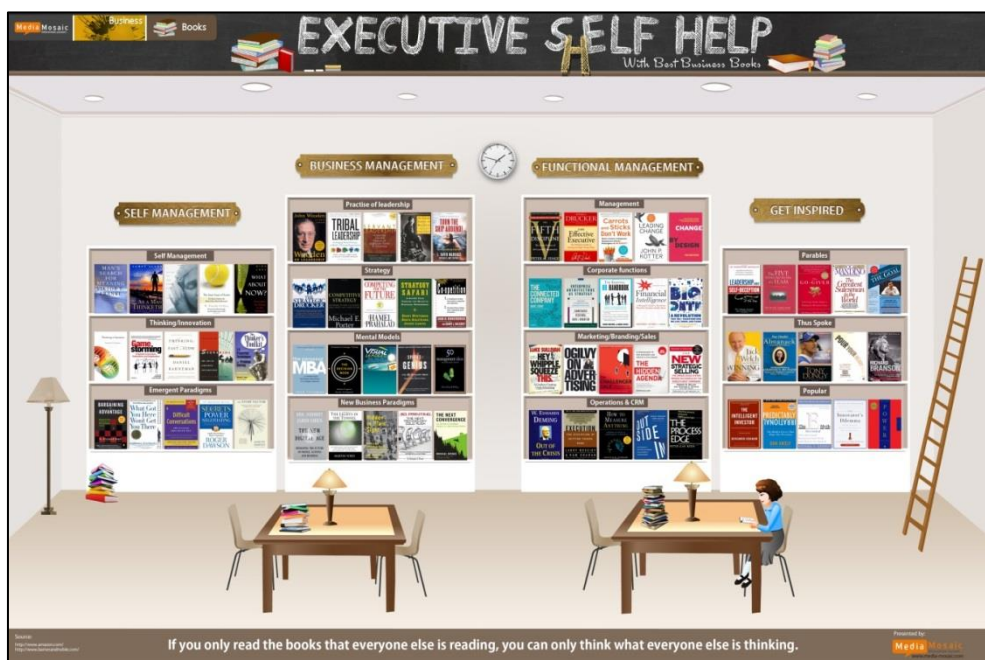
On-page Resources

Again, much in the same way that a whitepaper will add value to a customer's experience, additional on page resources such as Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) pages and a glossary of terms will help the user when visiting your site. You want visitors to keep returning to your site, and simple easy-to-use resources work wonders.

Visual Content Types

Infographics

To create something that is truly unique and shareable, look no further than Infographics. Visualising data and key information in an easy-to-read and user-friendly way is an excellent idea, and is the perfect type of content for social shares and links. As long as you've got a good topic, and amazing information to share, Infographics are worth it. There are also lots of [great tools](#) for creating Infographics.



This [business books infographic](#) presents lots of data really quickly

Interactive Data Visualisations

Taking data visuals to the next level can be done with interactive visual content. This can be seen with what's called HTML5 content, and allows users to actually engage with the content in a fun and actionable way. If you have plenty of data and information to share, this is also a great way of simplifying that information in a fun and easy-to-use way. If you are new to HTML5 [this guide](#) will get you started.

Images

Using images, either on their own or within content works really well, especially on social media. You can take and share pictures from events, locations, your place of business, or products. Featuring these images in your blog posts will help generate interest in your content, emphasise points, break up large bodies of content and improve your blog's SEO.

In addition, visual content can take the form of Memes and Gifs. As long as you own the rights to any image, it'll make perfect ammunition to your Content Marketing Arsenal.

Presentations

The [SlideShare](#) website allows users to share presentations with each other and has created the opportunity for people to make slide decks that are highly visual and then share them with a large audience. You can also embed these presentations in your own blog posts to give them an added visual edge in a small space.



We create slide decks to provide longer visual looks at key topics

Social Content Types

Webinars

Hosting webinars works well as a Content Marketing and Social Media strategy. If you want to share your industry knowledge on a particular subject, service, product or tool, then host a webinar. It's a great way to build your community of social followers, as well as provide them with useful content. Hubspot have a free guide on how to [setup a Webinar](#).

Hangouts

Much in the same way that webinars work, hangouts are great for interactivity with your audience on Google+. This could be a meet and greet, a discussion group, an exclusive look at a new product and so much more. Everything you need to know for your first Hangout can be [found here](#).

Twitter Chats

Interactivity with your audience is key and Twitter Chats work extremely well in this regard. Ask questions, start debates and discussions and reward people for their input and efforts. Here's a simple [guide to Twitter chats](#).



We have our own themed chats called #koozchat

Audio Content Types

Podcasts

These can be downloaded or streamed anywhere thanks to the prevalence of Smartphones, laptops and MP3 players. Expand on your message and produce podcasts with relevant interviews, industry stories, discussions, useful tips and advice. Detailed insights like this work especially well with B2B content for niche and interesting industries. [This five part guide](#) walks you through the steps involved.

Interviews With Industry Experts

Get an exclusive interview with either someone relevant to your industry or someone famous to endorse your product or service. Host these on your website or YouTube, either as an audio file or a video, and promote them via your social channels. Once shared they'll help generate social shares, links and ultimately referral traffic.

Video Content Types

Employee Guides

Create user-friendly guides to a particular service or tool by giving additional information and walking through the steps with one or more of your employees in front of the camera. This works really well on B2B content as it offers your industry audience further insights. You can also show you have a smart knowledgeable team, as we try to do with Koozai TV, where we create a guide with a different employee each week:



One of the employee videos on Koozai TV

Industry round-ups

For industries that have plenty going on, why not present weekly or bi-weekly round ups? It's a great way of condensing all the up-to-date and relevant industry related news and stories.

Product Guides

Videos work well in terms of B2C content as well. Perhaps you want to review a particular product, or give an exclusive insight into a new product. Alternatively, you could showcase your product's benefits in a fun and imaginative way.

We've taken a deeper look in to more types of video content and how to create them and launch them in our YouTube Video Marketing Guide which can be [found here](#).

Before You Get Started

Before you do anything ask yourself these questions:

- Do I have the time to commit to creating content?
- Do I have a compelling story to tell / topic to cover?
- Do I have an original idea that hasn't been done well elsewhere?
- Do I have a passion for writing and enjoy it?
- Would enough people want to buy it / download it / read it?

Tackling these questions will help you determine if you are ready and also if there is a market for the content. If the answer to any of the above questions is "no" then you've got a problem you need to solve before you can move forwards. If you get a "yes" to everything then congratulations you are ready to create content.

Content Strategy

Research & Preparation

Now that you have an idea of the types of content to create, you need to start to establish a Content Marketing strategy. What to create, when it needs to go live, who will create it and what are the goals and objectives? These are all questions you must ask yourself before you create a plan. Let's look at two of the biggest questions:

Identify Goals

Understand the business considerations that will inform your Content Marketing plan. Think about the actual goal of your content and what you want your content to do. The most common business considerations for Content Marketing include:

- Deliver traffic
- Build links
- Increase social shares
- Enhance brand awareness
- Gain business leads
- Contribute to sales

Most content will aim to deliver all six, but different types of content can achieve different things. You may rewrite product descriptions to improve sales and may create an Infographic purely to build brand awareness.

Once you've identified the goal you want to achieve with your content, the next step is to identify how this goal will be achieved – through an objective.

Identify Objectives

Each piece of content you create must have a clearly defined purpose to ensure it achieves the intended response. For example, your content should do at least one of the following:

- Entertain
- Inform
- Teach
- Inspire
- Persuade
- Reveal
- Share insights
- Be controversial
- Create a conversation
- Create a debate

With an idea of content types, as well as your goals and objectives, the next step is to establish what you actually need. This can be achieved with a content audit.

Perform A Content Audit

Creating a detailed and thorough content strategy will take time, although making the effort to do this in the first place will bring its own rewards. Within your overall strategy, there will be a number of areas that you will need to address, from how to promote the content once it's been created, how to measure its success and of course, undertaking the correct level of research before you get started.

With the right amount of research completed first, you will have a greater understanding of what you want to achieve from your campaigns and a clearer focus when it comes to creating content.

Whilst all of these elements are as equally valid as each other, they all combine to form the basis of your underlying content strategy. This is why you should assign a dedicated amount of time to each area. With this in mind, it's important that you place a key emphasis on the very first process by incorporating research.

To make everything clear from the outset, completing a content audit will help you to observe what forms of content are likely to be successful and what your competition in the market is currently working on. Furthermore, it will also act as a reference point whilst you are working on your campaigns and for the future too. So what areas should you spend time researching?

Current Engagement

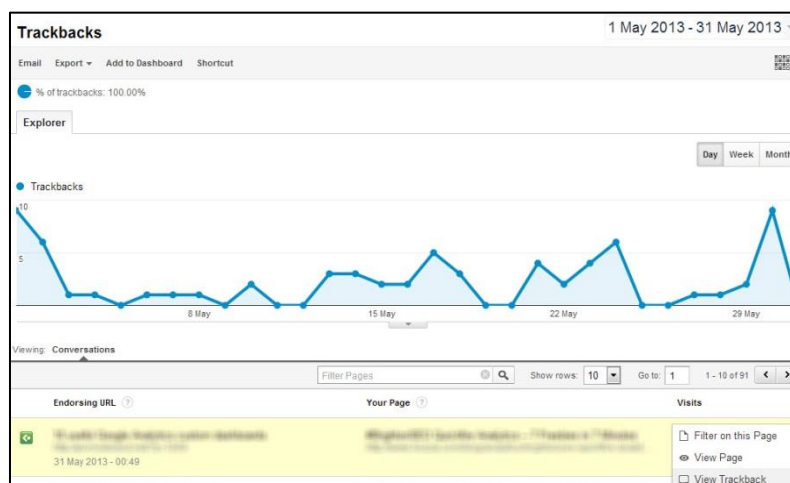
What forms of content are you currently working with that could be used as part of a more defined strategy? Perhaps you have started a blog but rarely update it? In this example, you could look to bring in more blog posts within your strategy so that you are really getting optimum performance out of this marketing channel. In contrast, you might have found that video marketing has worked well, so again more video content could be used in the same way.

Competitor Content

Researching what your competitors are doing in the market will also give you a good indication of the different forms of content that are currently working well. It will also allow you to spot any potential gaps in the market to aim for too. It's worth using [Majestic SEO](#), a great tool that allows you to view the amount and source of backlinks pointing to a particular domain to help you do this. Once you establish the kind of sites that are using content, you can then target those within your strategy, or at least find ones that are very similar to approach.

Areas To Improve

Having a greater understanding of your own website statistics will help you to know where to focus your attention. By using Google Analytics you can visualise the current levels of traffic you are receiving across your site. This will allow you to view which pages and keywords are slightly underperforming and then incorporate these within your content strategy. You can also research which pages are performing well and seek to strengthen the authority of these pages to maintain their rankings.



Using the trackbacks report feature in Google Analytics also enables you to see which websites are currently linking to you. As a result, you can aim to target these sites once your content has been written. As they have already linked to you before, they are likely to be more receptive in featuring you again as a result.

All of this initial research will give you a clear focus of what you should include within your content strategy and give you an indication of what is likely to be successful. Spending time researching at this stage will save you time in the long run as your campaigns will become more targeted. Having an idea of the current level of activity of some of your key competitors will also enable you to focus on the best forms of content too. This knowledge is far greater to you than just simply ploughing into any campaign with no real focus or idea of what content you should create and where you should try and place it.

Social Engagement

With the shareability of content taking on increasing importance, it's vital to know what content has been shared the most, and by whom. In addition, looking at the social engagement of your competitors' content should underpin the content plan you create moving forwards. This can be achieved in a number of ways.

Google Analytics allows you to see detailed social activity, giving you an understanding of the best performing social channels for a particular piece of content. This information can be accessed under "Traffic Sources" then "Social" and "Network Referrals". From here you can see the different types of social networks, as well as the best performing pieces of content driving traffic from that social network.

Social Network	Visits	↓
1. [REDACTED]	2,149	
2. [REDACTED]	867	
3. [REDACTED]	841	
4. [REDACTED]	667	
5. [REDACTED]	282	

An example Network Referrals report with Social Network names removed

Additionally, within Google Analytics there is a Data Hub Activity feature which gives you great insights into who has engaged, shared and discussed your content across a number of Google-partner social media channels. This allows you to see how successful a piece of content was in being shared, and more specifically who has shared that content, thanks to Google Ripples. Not only does this give you an idea of the types of socially successful content to create, but also who to target specifically when it comes to content promotion.

Furthermore, you'll want to see how socially successful your competitors' content is. While you won't have access to their Analytics account, there are some really handy tools to help.

[Followerwonk](#) is one of the best tools to give you extensive Twitter data, so you can understand more about yours and your competitors' followers and the types of content they tweet. Additionally you can find and connect with influencers of a particular niche and track followers. What's really helpful is that you can compare your social graph with competitors and utilise the findings to enhance your content campaigns by creating really targeted content. Similarly, Google Ripples, allows you to see who has shared content – this can be used during your competitor analysis to understand their influencers and the right type of targeted content to create.

Establish Personas

Now that you have performed your content audit, the next stage is to map this content to the types of people who would enjoy it. You can do this by using personas, which are stripped down versions of the different types of people who could interact with your brand.

Your marketing and sales team may already have this information and if nothing else they will certainly have a good idea of what their target customers looks like. This would typically include but is not limited to:

- Their age range
- Their typical gender
- Job title
- Occupation
- Their role in decision making
- The types of products they buy
- Their interests

So for example "Gemma is a 35 year old web designer who heads up the online marketing department and is keen to learn more about Content Marketing. In order to gain approval for new projects she must heavily research them, which is why she regularly purchases video guides for quick tips on marketing although she prefers to absorb long content in text format."

When writing this guide we could use personas like the above to determine that the best way to market to Gemma would be to create video guides (which we do on Koozai TV) and a long detailed guide (such as this [whitepaper](#)).

Of course Gemma, and the personas you create, shouldn't just be a gut feeling of what you feel the market wants. They should be based on research between your sales and marketing team and your own knowledge of the market you operate in. You can also survey your existing customers to help understand why they purchased and the pitfalls they had to overcome.

If you have no idea of what your ideal customer looks like then that's far more important than what content you should write and is the first thing you need to complete. [This guide is great](#) at helping outline the basics.

Keyword Research

Keywords are a fundamental part of SEO and Content Marketing, so you need to make sure your titles and topics are well-optimised with targeted keywords, or themes. This often gets overlooked during the planning phase, but it's essential to write about something with a search demand, otherwise there's little point in creating the content in the first place.

The first thing to understand is what type of keyword you are going to use.

- Root keyword – This is the main keyword that you are aiming for, e.g. flights, computers, garden tools.
- Qualifier keywords – These are added word(s) to your root keyword. This usually revolves around an adjective (e.g. cheap), a brand (e.g. British Airways), location (e.g. Spain), in addition to application, product type, or product feature.
- Modifiers – These are keywords that are similar but are slightly modified, e.g. cheap, cheaper, cheapest.
- Synonyms – Usually people won't always search for the same keyword, e.g. car insurance, motor insurance.
- Singular/Plural – Some searches will include pluralised words as well as singular ones, e.g. garden tool, garden tools.

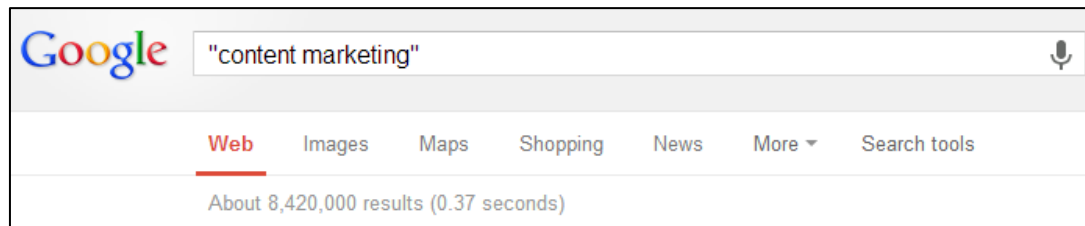
What's important here is to see that the root keyword may not always be the keyword you target, but that by targeting a keyword with a modifier you can still have that word on the page and also target a term that is more realistic. Write down all of the terms that are important to you (root keywords) and then complete the following:

1. Use any of the following: [Google AdWords Tool](#), [Keyword Eye](#), [WordStream](#)
2. Enter root keywords to get an idea of search volume and log this information in to a spreadsheet (you can export .csv files from all three of these tools).

☐	☒ Save all	Search terms (1)	
Keyword		Competition	Global Monthly Searches ?
☐	content marketing ▼	High	90,500
☐	☒ Save all	Keyword ideas (100)	
Keyword		Competition	Global Monthly Searches ?
☐	content marketing agency ▼	High	1,600
☐	content marketing institute ▼	Low	2,900
☐	content marketing strategy ▼	High	3,600
☐	what is content marketing ▼	High	90,500
☐	content marketing jobs ▼	Medium	480
☐	content marketing world ▼	Low	1,300

An example search on Google Keyword Tool

3. Enter the best performing keywords into Google with quotation marks to get an idea of competition and write down how many other pages exist for that term.



There are 8,420,000 results on Google for "Content Marketing", clearly this would be a very hard keyword to go after

4. Filter highly competitive keywords from less competitive with a high search volume. This will tell you which keywords are achievable and which ones have far too much competition.

	A	B	C
1		Searches	Competition
2	content marketing agency	1,600	4,760,000
3	content marketing institute	2,900	1,760,000
4	content marketing strategy	3,600	24,300,000
5	what is content marketing	90,500	1,030,000
6	content marketing jobs	480	1,070,000
7	content marketing world	1,300	1,770,000

In this example "what is content marketing" has a very high volume of searches, but the least competition - so it would be a good term to target

5. Tailor your titles around root keywords, using qualifiers (e.g. an adjective added to your root keyword), modifiers (e.g. similar keywords that are slightly modified) and synonyms as well as singulars and plurals

We'll look at how to use keywords in the text later on. At this stage you will be armed with content activities, goals, objectives, a complete picture of the content you need to create and the right types of keywords, so it's now time to start planning.

Content Planning

To get more of an insight into the types of content to create, it's a good idea to collaborate with other teams and agencies, if you or your client has other projects on-the-go.

Working With Other Agencies or Teams

For any Content Marketer, creating content ideas with traction is arguably the toughest, but also the most exciting and rewarding part of any campaign. Whether you're working client side or in-house, your job can be made all the more easier, just by liaising with other agencies. In the below example we cover PR agencies but much of this is applicable to any agency relationship.

1. Arrange A Kick-off Meeting/Call

Whether you're working in-house or agency side, be sure to get in touch with your, or your client's PR team/agency. Believe me; they will be just as interested in what you do, as you are in what they do. So touching base initially is a great way to build bridges, contacts and networks. Have an idea of what you would like to discuss, with a series of questions. It's important to have an end goal, so whether it's just to make initial contact, or whether you'd like something more out of it such as campaign ideas, be sure to know what you want from it first.

2. Discuss Any Previous Or Future Campaigns

The best way PRs can help with your Content Marketing campaigns is by discussing what they have worked on in the past, and what campaigns/ideas they have coming up in the future. In doing so, you'll have a better understanding of what the company/client has already worked on and what plans they have for the future. An ideal scenario is if the PR department or agency were working on a specific area, such as a new line of products or services. This gives you a rich area of ideas in which to tap.

3. Ask For Any Additional Material

With this in mind, ask the PR department/agency if they can provide you with additional material that they have or will be working on in the near future. Photos, images, testimonials, scripts, interviews, but also market research, customer research and data. Data driven content is going to be huge in the future; the better the data, the more unique and the better the quality of your content. As a result, ask if they have ever performed any market research and ask if you can use the stats too.

4. Co-ordinate Your Efforts

Any campaign will benefit from a coordinated approach. In other words, if you and the PR department/agency are working on the same campaign, then, in theory, it will only serve your campaign well.

Let's say, for example, that the PR agency has recently embarked on a fundraising campaign for charity. The agency have set about creating all sorts of offline material, perhaps an interview here, a media appearance there; but they have very little idea of what to do online. Well, here's where a coordinated approach will work wonders. Such an idea provides a rich tapestry of online content; blog posts, video interviews, media links, photos and all sorts. Two different disciplines, working towards the same goal.

5. Keep Them In The Loop

Once you have established a plan for your content or have come up with a number of ideas, simply let the PR agency/department know about it. They also revolve around ideas in their business, so sharing a few ideas here and there will help to coordinate your efforts and also strengthen any connection or relationship between the two.

6. Give Them SEO Tips

Another way of working with a PR agency is by giving them a few SEO tips. Now, we're not talking about overwhelming them with everything you know, just the relevant basics that apply to content. You'll be surprised to hear that a number of PR teams and agencies are actively learning more about SEO. So, a little helping hand along the way will go far – which leads us nicely onto the next point.

7. Ask For PR Tips

If you don't ask, you don't get; so be sure to ask for a few PR tips. Whether that's pitching to a blogger/website, or even getting a name or number from someone high profile at the website you really want a link from. Obviously, you would need to have built up a good working relationship with any PR before delving straight into, "do you know anyone at the BBC?" but a few PR tips may well work wonders for your SEO campaigns.

8. Don't Tread On Their Toes

This leads us nicely onto the final tip; whilst it's all well and good working together, sharing ideas and tips, you really don't want to be treading on their toes, asking too much from them, or annoying them in any way. If you're working on behalf of an agency, they could easily go straight back to the client and complain. Don't go in all guns blazing. Start off slowly; establish ideas and share tips and tools, but do not expect to get names, contacts and links at the drop of a hat. Work with them to achieve the same goal, and that's all that counts.

Creating Your Content Plan

With the insights you have gained from looking at your current content activity, competitor analysis and talking to other departments/agencies, it's now time to start formulating your plans. You would have no doubt jotted down a number of ideas, but if you still need a bit more help, consider the following tips.

- Ensure you have a piece of content for each persona
- Remember the goal and objective for each piece of content
- Consider the best types of activities that have worked in the past
- Consider the best types of activities that have worked for your competitors
- Factor in who has shared content and what that content was
- Factor in key dates, events and seasonality
- Piggyback off current affairs and current events
- Ask your client or in-house teams about other projects, competitions and upcoming events
- Ask if your in-house teams or other sources have conducted useful market research, which can be used to create ideas
- Think about common customer problems and create a solution

When it comes to creating a plan, it's vital that you incorporate a blend of content activities and content objectives. If you rely on one particular activity, your content will lose its effectiveness amongst your audience. Additionally, from a search engines perspective, a blend of activity that's generating traffic, links and shares is often far more successful than routinely creating content to game its algorithm.

For example, you may want to create daily blog posts, weekly videos and monthly Infographics. In addition, as an objective you may want to *inform* daily, *reveal insights* weekly and create something *entertaining* monthly.

When establishing your ideas, you need to consider publication dates, key dates, key events and seasonality. This will help when it comes to the next phase of planning, your editorial calendar.

It's best to plan your content output over a defined period; for example, a three month, six month or yearly period.

When creating an editorial calendar you can either use existing templates, like this one from [Optimizebook](#), or you can create your own using Excel and Outlook. Whichever you decide, it's important to ensure your editorial plan/calendar details the following information:

- What will be created
- When it will be created
- Who will create it
- A due date

Using an editorial calendar is a great way to visualise your plan, ensure you are always ahead of where you need to be and hold people accountable to tasks.

Using Project Management Tools

There are a number of project management tools and software available to help make the content creation process coherent. Depending on the size of your project will determine the effectiveness of each project management tool. Tools we recommend are:

- Lighthouse
- Springloops
- CreativePro Office
- Jumpchart
- No Kahuna
- Basecamp
- Sugar CRM



Two of our favourite CRM tools

Whichever tool you use, you want to clearly lay out the following:

- All of the content that is to be created
- The individual in charge of the content
- The finer details of each piece of content, including the brief and links to resources
- Contact details of important people on the project
- A due date (really important)

Whether you have one content campaign to manage or hundreds, you'll also want to visualise the progress of each piece of content. Create an editorial progress report for all your content, to establish where in the creation process each piece of content is. Each progress report will look different, but the following are some key moments during the content creation process that you'll want to know have been reached:

- Outreach for writing spot
- Sourcing of writing spot
- Researching content idea
- Writing/creating content
- Proofreading content
- Submitting content to client/writing spot
- Publication of content

For campaigns involving a number of different people, you'll want to assign tasks and due dates for each task. This will hold your content creators accountable to the tasks assigned to them, and will keep the content creation process on-track.

Researching Ideas

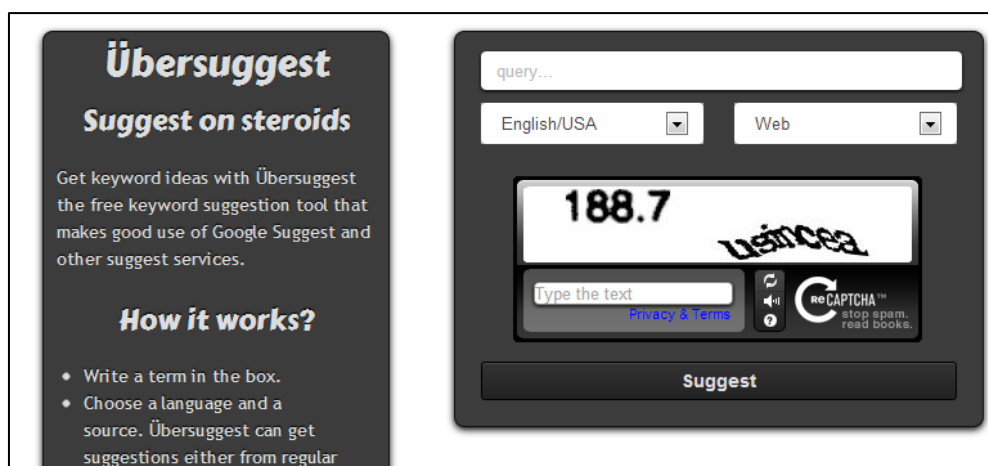
The research process is really dependent on the type of content you will be creating. For example, you may need to factor in outreach time, researching effective titles, what to include, who to include, as well as keywords. With this in mind, let's take a look at each aspect in more detail.

Creating Content Titles

An effective Content Marketing title can make all the difference to your campaigns. Whether it's the number of social shares, Click through Rate, traffic or conversions, a well-researched and strategically planned title can massively help your efforts.

A lot can be said for a good headline. You only have to look at the tabloids to know that an attention grabbing headline sells newspapers. "How Do You Solve a Problem Like Korea?" or "Super Caley Go Ballistic Celtic Are Atrocious" are just some of the more famous ones that spring to mind. Whilst your Content Marketing titles don't all have to be award winning headlines, crammed with clever puns, they do need to stand-out, drive traffic, and engage your audience. So how is this possible?

Whether it's blog posts, guest posts, infographics, press releases, whitepapers, user guides, social media updates, you name it, all of your efforts will be in vain if no one actually clicks on the link. Gone are the days of creating content for content's sake – it needs to be working for you and your campaigns; the Return on Investment is the bottom line.



Übersuggest is a great tool for checking ideas around a particular keyword

Here's a breakdown of some of the types of titles and topics you could include:

Targeted

1. First things first, make sure your titles actually fulfil a need or purpose. If you spend hours if not days creating a single piece of content, make sure you know there's an audience for it. Target each persona you want to reach with the type of content you have identified that they will enjoy. Use analytics to get an idea of the best and worst performing pages on your site; popular pages indicate a high interest in a particular product and service, so it might be worth creating something around that
2. Use analytics to look at searched for queries, this will give you an idea of the types of content to create, about a particular product or service in far greater detail
3. Look at blog comments from customers and site visitors – are they suggesting or asking after anything in particular?
4. Check any feedback emails or frequently asked questions from site visitors
5. Use social media tools like [FollowerWonk](#), [Social Bro](#) and [Google Ripples](#) to see the types of content and titles around your niche that people are interacting with and sharing



A few of tools you can use to check for popular content

Shareable

Content Marketing and Social Media share a symbiotic relationship, effectively meaning they're dependent on each other. Moreover, it's now imperative that your content not only does well within search engines, but that it's making an impact on social media too. Social exposure will introduce your content to new people, and any interaction or signals are good indicators to search engines, and are believed to help with rankings. Therefore, you need to ensure the titles are user friendly and so captivating that people will want to share them.

1. Find who has shared similar content, using the above tools
2. Look at the titles of the most shared content
3. When promoting your content, target these influential people
4. Make sure your titles are small enough and engaging enough for people to share them easily

Unique

Granted, there's a lot of duplication going on within the online world, but in fairness, Panda has worked well in weeding out thin and highly-spun content, created just for the sake of it. For your content to stand the best chance of being shared and viewed, you need to make sure your title is completely unique.

1. Put your title in quotation marks and perform a search – if there are no results, it's completely unique

No results found for **"chicken farming all weather tips"**.

Creative

On the subject of making your titles stand out, you need to think beyond the search engines – it's time to consider how the user responds to specific titles. Using this information, as well as injecting your own creativity will help you to create truly effective titles.

1. Take a look at your data from Analytics and the above tools, are there specific titles that worked better than others?
2. In any way you can, look to be different and offer your audience something they have never seen before, that follows what worked before for you
3. Some good examples of effective titles revolve around: 'tips, lists, secrets, how to's, interviews, opinion pieces'

Engaging

Speaking of creative titles, it's also worth considering how engaged your audience will be when they read your content. What's your goal here? Is it just to increase social shares, or do you want to start to build and engage with your audience? If so, then think about the following:

1. Gather industry opinions
2. Where possible, leave open ended questions
3. Entice others to share their opinions or experiences
4. Potentially create something controversial to create a reaction (a word of caution not to do anything damaging to your brand though)

Current

Even the most highly targeted and relevant titles often can't compete against a title that is very fresh and current. This won't always get you long-term traffic, but it will certainly help gain additional traffic through very minimal effort.

1. To help, consider the following tools: [Google Trends](#), [Uber Suggest](#), [Content Strategy Generator](#)
2. Look for subjects and topics that are peaking and rising in search demand
3. Establish a list of forthcoming events to piggyback off – check the search demand against these
4. Work with a specialist in that area to get an idea of future topics and trends

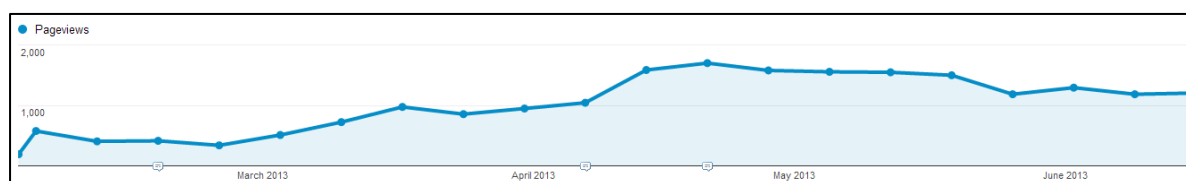


Excellent tools for finding current topics to write about

Evergreen

On the flipside of short-term gains, are the titles that will continue to drive traffic after fads have passed. Evergreen content is that which continues to deliver traffic, because your titles are still useful and relevant to the reader. Think about the following:

1. Use analytics to discover content that has delivered consistent traffic over-time
2. Look to create titles around guides and instructions
3. Write in-depth research pieces
4. Give solutions to common problems



The content in this example started slowly but now generates regular views

Researching Content Topics

Knowing what to include and how to include it is underpinned by your content goal and objective. Therefore, what you need to research will really depend on the type of content you're creating and the goal and objective of the piece. Nevertheless there are some things to consider before putting pen to paper (figuratively speaking).

Specify Time

Your Content Marketing campaign will be set by a budget and time, so make sure you conduct the necessary research in the right amount of time. This will help you keep on-track for your due date.

Utilise Time

If you've planned in multiple types of content around a similar theme or topic, then use this to your advantage. Once you have a strong understanding of your subject matter, make sure you make the most of this by getting as much as you can from that single idea.

Use Leading Resources

There's nothing worse than getting your facts wrong, so make sure you are using industry leading resources. For example, locate governing bodies, councils, committees, research councils and market research companies for information and data.

Speak To Experts

Follow this up by contacting experts within the industry. If you need a quick answer, then locate an individual and see if they have shared relevant information online. Alternatively, if you have time, ask for an interview.

Speak To Clients/In-house Teams

No one is going to know a particular area better than your client or relevant in-house team. Arm yourself with the necessary questions and take down as much information as possible.

Outreach

Depending on the type of content you wish to create, you may need to factor in outreach time. This is for content such as Guest Posts, Blogger Reviews or if you wish to feature a specialist or expert comment(s) within your piece.

Although it may seem odd to do the outreach before you write content we find this is vital in ensuring that content never goes to waste. If you are writing content to be placed on another website there is no point writing it without first finding somewhere that would like to include it.

If you are writing content for your website, outreach is less essential however you should still research the other sites out there to ensure you are producing content on a similar level of quality. It's also worth speaking to other sites in your niche to build connections that may share your content or help you in the future

Types of Sites to Consider

The sites you choose must be of a good quality. This is not just reflected in PageRank, or AlexaRank, but the types of content on the site and the quality of that content. You want to ensure the site has a social following with engagement. If a site is what's known as a 'content dump' that only publishes guest posts simply for optimisation purposes, then it's best to avoid all together. With this in mind, here are some guidelines on what you should and shouldn't be looking for. First up avoid the following types of sites:

- Content dumps
- Openly advertised guest posts, with a price list
- Those with an external links page
- Those with a blogroll
- Poorly designed sites
- Those with too much advertising
- Spammy comment
- Irrelevant content to the theme of the site

Look at the following types of sites:

- Well designed
- Content with a common theme
- Social media accounts for the site/company
- Social media accounts for employees/writers
- With lots of engagement (social shares and comments)
- Regular content that gets published
- With an editorial process

You'll end up with a much smaller list this way which means you can spend longer focusing on each site, something that is very important in effective outreach.

Finding Opportunities

The important thing to remember when it comes to outreach is that you're trying to connect with people, not websites. Simply finding a relevant site and using their Contact Us form with a generic outreach email is only going to result in a poor response rate. The best thing to do is to find the right types of sites first, and then the right people on that site.

Finding the right sites involves a mixture of the following techniques:

Gorkana PR and HARO

These are two tried and tested sources to use when conducting outreach: [Gorkana](#) and [HARO](#). Both services allow journalists to request people to be quoted on or write about various topics. Generally speaking the sites are good quality, but the downside is that most of the journalists who use this site may not use your quote or get back to you.

FollowerWonk

Within this tool you can search the Twitter bios of users. You can see the types of content they are sharing on a regular basis and a link back to the site they are promoting. From here you can analyse the site, and if it ticks all the boxes you have a real person to outreach to – also saving you time later on in the process.

Scan Social Media

Much in the same way you use Followerwonk, why not search on social media yourself for opportunities. Google Plus and Twitter are inundated with requests from people asking for sources and a good hashtag to follow is #journorequest. Be sure to check the site first before you reply.

My Blog Guest

[This service](#) connects those looking for guest post opportunities with sites who want to write about those topics. Again, this saves you a great deal of time researching the name and contact details of the site owner or editor, but you do have to consider the type of site complies with the earlier points highlighted.

Technorati

[This tool](#) allows you to search for industry relevant blogs. It's a very quick and easy way to build up a list of sites to target. Not all of them would have accepted guest posts before, which is fine, but you'll need to conduct further research into the right person to contact at the site. Don't let the "tech" part of the name fool you as they cover all kinds of industries.



In this example Technorati found 4530 blogs about insurance, plenty of opportunities!

Competitor Research

You may have already established a number of potential sites based on your competitor research during the Content Marketing audit phase. If not, go back and use a tool like [Majestic SEO](#) to analyse where your competitors are getting their links from. If they have written a guest post for a particular site, make a note of that site, and the content they created.

Finding Contact Details

When you find a website you want to write for, you need to find the following:

- The name and URL of the website
- A relevant blog post to your topic
- An author or editor on the site
- Contact details for the author / editor

If you cannot find the editor or site owner's name or contact details, then consider:

- Looking for an author name on recent posts
- Using a [Whois search](#) to establish the site owner's name
- Scanning social media profiles for the author's name
- Using LinkedIn to search for the site owner

This information will be essential for formulating an outreach email which we will look at below. You can also find a telephone number and use that but remember that you should not just call up and ask for a link – explain how content works and how a featured article will work well on the site. Find an angle; it could be a follow up piece to another article they've written. What you're offering needs to add value, otherwise you'll just get a rejection.

Awful Examples of Outreach

Before you approach anyone it's important to understand what not to say. To help with that here are some of the worst outreach emails we've received.

Irrelevant Titles

By far the most outrageous guest blog request we have received was this one:

Could you be interested in a guest post about saving money on your mortgage by taking out and paying back payday loans?

Aside from being unethical, ultimately this is about lazy keyword research. Yes people search for "payday loans" and "mortgages", but please don't put them together in an article title in an attempt to nab some traffic.

If you're going to pitch a guest post title then at least think about whether the article is:

- a) Good content
- b) Something people want to read
- c) Not going to get the blog owner in trouble
- d) Ethical / legal / something you'd want your family to read and action

Copy, Paste, Copy, Paste

Another symptom of "let's write as much as we can and get as many links as we can" is that so many outreach emails are just dire, often feeling exactly like any other type of web spam. If your outreach email seems of the same quality as "we would like to wire you \$100 million from our country's Prince" then you're doing something wrong.

Dear owner of <http://www.koozai.com>,

Hi

My name is _____ and I'm dropping you a line to see if you accept guest bloggers on [<http://www.koozai.com>]. I write about SEO; and I thought an article about the same would be a good fit for your blog.

Which is why the above email is so frustrating. We're called Koozai not [<http://www.koozai.com>], which just smacks of lazy copy and pasting or automatic form filling. It's also very easy to find the name of someone to address the email to. The email is specific enough to reference that we do SEO so that's a start, but ultimately there's been very little research in to who we are. Mail merge should stay in Word.

Lack of Research

We are not suggesting that every pitch we get should have read our backlog of posts, and researched the author's family history, but it's so frustrating when people see guest post requests and go "Oh he accepts guest posts, I'll try my luck". So this type of email is just lazy.

```
Since you accept guest posts, I plan to submit an article  
"How to Buy  
Your Really Desired Wedding Dress Online". It has never been
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In other words; "As you accept guest posts, here's one completely unrelated to what you do". When we get a nicely written email that we can tell is specific to us we always keep a good impression of that person. If we see them on Twitter we'll likely start up a conversation. If you send us questions in the future we will answer them. That's a good investment in time.

Legal Issues

Sometimes people even submit stolen content, which is something to watch for if you are accepting guest posts. One of the articles sent to us was discovered – thanks to [Copyscape](#) – to be stolen. Even a quick Google search with speechmarks found the original source, and it was clear as day that the author who had sent it to us had not written it originally. He didn't even change the title of the blog post...

The most insulting thing of all was what he wrote on the original email with the article:

```
> Hi Mike,  
> Here is a post on the above mentioned topic. I can assure  
you of its quality and uniqueness. Some screenshots are  
attached with the post.
```

Interestingly this was a writer claiming to be from a big website. It was a case of outsourcing SEO and finding that one of the writers wasn't as ethical as he promised. Thankfully when we reported this to the brand, they found the person responsible and changed their SEO strategy, but it could have done serious damage to their brand.

All of the above emails have forgotten the golden rule. That outreach isn't about you, it's about the blog owner. They have to be happy and get something in the process. Blog owners (the ones with blogs worth targeting anyway) want amazing content that will get them more traffic. If you can give them that, then they will listen.

Excellent Examples

Now we have identified the many pitfalls of bad outreach, let's look at how it can be done correctly. We will break down how a good email can be written but more importantly than that we'll explain why each part works because ultimately great outreach doesn't rely on mail merge style email templates, it relies on emails written specifically for each person.

Named Individuals Only

The first thing to consider is that if you are not going to start an outreach email with a person's name then you may as well not send it. The chance of an email being accepted that isn't written to a specific person is very low. Likewise generic email addresses like info@ and company@ also rarely bear fruit. Earlier we looked at ways to find these contact details so ensure you use them.

A Very Quick Introduction

It can be quite tempting to start with a long intro that explains why you love the blog or a big explanation on why you are contacting them. Neither of these ideas are wrong in principle but you have to get to the point quickly.

Therefore our preferred approach is to start the email by referencing a similar post on their website. For example:

"I really enjoyed your blog post on holidays to the Seychelles and would love to suggest a follow-up."

We also prefer not to use the term "guest post" in the email at all. This can put people off very quickly and has been tainted through overuse of the term.

Introduce Your Expertise

The next sentence should cover what you can deliver and why content from you or your client would be exceptional. The goal here is to make them interested in the value you offer, rather than trying to offer a generic post.

"Holidays XYZ have been providing Seychelles travel for 10 years and they would love to write a post on the following topics."

Here we've established who the company are, the fact that they want to write and why the content will be great.

Provide Topic Options

We would then provide 2-3 different examples of topics that are relevant to the initial blog post. This gives the blogger a choice of what they would like us to cover and can help prove that we are knowledgeable on different topics. So in this case we could suggest:

"The Top 10 Reasons To Visit The Seychelles"

"15 Must Visit Destinations In The Seychelles"

"Money Saving Tips For The Seychelles"

Wrap It Up

We like to keep outreach emails short and to the point so would end simply by putting the onus on the blog owner to reply and confirm if they would be happy to receive the content. We also offer up examples of content but do not link to them (in order to keep the email short). This could look as:

"If either of these topics sound of interest please let me know and I will get the content written right away. I am also happy to provide examples of other content we have written."

We'd then finish with a range of contact details so they can get in touch. The finished example would look like:

"Hi John,

I really enjoyed your blog post on holidays to the Seychelles and would love to suggest a follow-up. Holidays XYZ have been providing Seychelles travel for 10 years and they would love to write a post on the following topics.

- The Top 10 Reasons To Visit The Seychelles
- 15 Must Visit Destinations In The Seychelles
- Money Saving Tips For The Seychelles

If any of these topics sound of interest please let me know and I will get the content written right away. I am also happy to provide examples of other content we have written.

Kind Regards

Mike Essex
CONTACT DETAILS"

Short and sweet. With a very similar template to the one above we achieved a 50% acceptance rate in the travel niche which offered more than enough high quality blogs for the particular client.

Follow-up

The last thing to bear in mind is if you do get a positive reply you need to get on it right away. Confirm that you can write the content and ensure that you deliver it on time and to any requirements the blog asks for.

If you get a negative reply it is always best to respond in a polite manner and ensure you update your records so you do not waste time on the same website. If they have left the door open for a future opportunity then also add this to your records.

If the blog asks you to pay to post on their website you should only accept if you ask them to "nofollow" the links back to your website. This means you won't get any value from the links so it would only be worth writing for them if you feel you will get brand awareness and traffic. Generally we only write for sites that are free so this is something you need to consider.

Should you hear no reply then you should follow-up on your initial email within a week and ask if you can provide any further information. Should you receive nothing after that it's generally best to move on and try again when you have another topic at a later date.

Preparation

Whether you are placing your content on your own website or elsewhere you need to consider how it will be promoted once it is live. No great piece of content will ever perform well unless you have the means to tell people that it is there. This work has to start before you have even written a single word or drawn any pixels.

These are a few of the ways we recommend to ensure everything is set to build up an early buzz.

Email Lists

Along with their name, an email address is the single best piece of information someone can give you. It can help you discover where they work and who they are, which is ideal for checking that your targeted customers (personas) are viewing your content. This is why you should try and build email collection into everything you do. This can be done via:

- Extra content for subscribers
- Product notifications
- Shopping carts
- Login areas
- RSS feeds with email newsletters
- Other email newsletters
- Competitions

Before you add content to your site you should include at least some of these methods. It means when your content goes live you will be able to learn more about your readers and that you can hopefully have long term conversations with them which may result in sales. You should ask for permission to email them further content.

Having a strong email list also means that when you launch your content, or follow up content with further pieces, you have a list of people who you can notify. At Koozai we have a monthly newsletter that shares some of our new content which people can subscribe to. This means we know every month we will reach part of our target market and we can ensure they are aware of any really big pieces of content we have created.



An example piece of content from our monthly email

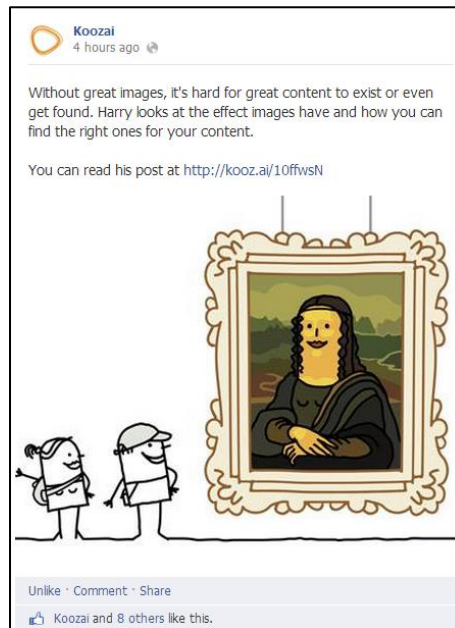
Social Media

There are two important considerations to make with regards to Social Media. The first is that at the very least you should set your brand up on the major platforms so that you can start building a following. Then when you have content to share you can reach people in this way. Platforms we recommend as a minimum are:

- Twitter
- Google+
- Facebook
- LinkedIn
- Pinterest
- YouTube
- Slideshare

In addition to this there are over 300 minor social platforms that it is worth registering your brand on. The longer you leave this the more chance there is of someone else taking your brand name, which can be hard to get back. To check which profiles are still available use [Knowem](#) and register any that have not been taken.

Once you have these profiles you should start sharing content regularly, including content that is not from your own website, to start to build up a loyal user base. Then when you have excellent content you can share it.



We use images on our Facebook pages to ensure they stand out

The next factor to consider is whether or not your site or the one you are posting to has Social Sharing buttons. These can be a great way to gain extra exposure by making it really easy for people to share your content directly from the piece. At Koozai we use these at the top and bottom of blog posts so people have two opportunities to share.

Much like the above, the platforms we recommend are:

- Twitter
- Google+
- Facebook
- LinkedIn
- StumbleUpon

You could also choose another site such as Pinterest if you have visual imagery but it's important not to give too many options so as not to overwhelm users.



Make it as easy as possible for people to share your content

Authorship

If you've ever seen a search result with a person's face next to it, then you have seen a result with authorship. This commonly looks like the one below:



Google are moving away from a web of things (like links) to a web of people and a big part of this is authorship. It is strongly believed that articles written by strong authors will rank better in the future, all other factors being equal, and the best thing is you can start building up your authorship now.

In the above image you can see that Mike's face is shown in the results, and this is because he has set up authorship using the rel="author" tag. To do this we had to do two things:

- On the article itself there is a link to Mike's Google+ page which has been marked up with the code rel="author"
- On Mike's Google+ page he lists Koozai under the "contributor to" section

This tells Google that Mike is the author of that article as well as any others he has written on Koozai.com. The search engine can then see what content Mike writes and start to build up a picture of the type of niches that he is influential on. If Mike also uses this markup on articles he writes on other websites then Google can also start to apply added value to them.

The principle behind this is that if Mike frequently writes great content on a topic, which Google can see based on how many shares it gets and other factors, then new content he writes on the same topic could rank better as a result.

To apply this to your own business you should ensure all of your authors have Google+ pages and that they use them regularly. You then need to add rel="author" tags to link their content to these profiles. The sooner you can do this the better.

You can learn more about adding the code [here](#).

Networking

Setting up business social media profiles is one way to start speaking to people in your niche. It's a way of getting 'many to one' contact with the people who embody your personas, but it's important to also have 'one to one' contact with them as well.

This can also be achieved on social media by encouraging employees to speak to your customers or answering queries on a person by person basis from your main social media account.

Earlier in this whitepaper we discussed how to find people on Followerwonk and that type of research is also great here. If you find people who are relevant to your niche then you can start talking to them and trying to strike up a common interest. Growing this relationship could result in them sharing your content in the future.

Likewise, offline networking can work even better and if you frequently attend industry events you can form alliances that can help in the long term. [Meetup](#) lets you see events that are happening in thousands of different industries, many of which are free, and regularly checking the site and attending events can rapidly fill up your list of contacts.

You can also hold your own events through the site if there is nothing of interest. The more you can give back to your community and form friendships, the more people you can ask for help when your content goes live.

EgoBait

One last factor to consider with networking is that you may identify people who are very high profile but who do not respond when you try to talk to them on Social Media. Quite often the best way to get their support is to mention them in your content where it is relevant.

For example, some of our most successful pieces of content have named people in the industry who are influential or have mentioned resources that we love. We then contacted those people and companies when the content went live and they shared it with their followers and in many cases followed us back.

Later on they shared content that did not involve them, because the association had been formed early on. This is the absolute best case scenario and when it works is incredibly powerful. The best way to test the water with this is to create an article that looks specifically at the most influential people in your sector. These posts are typically easy to create and can generate a lot of early buzz for your company.

Data Gathering

What Is Data-Driven Content?

It's pretty much what it says on the tin, content that has been created off the back of data and research. Whether this is from market research, surveys, questionnaires, or even existing public data from various online resources, data-driven content must be part of your Content Marketing arsenal.

It's a practice that has really been born out of what's known as [data-driven journalism](#), whereby a journalist would take a data set and turn this into a news item or story. The art of data-driven content comes with how you actually present the data, and turn this into something newsworthy, readable, shareable and so on.

Great data does not always mean great content - this is where the art of storytelling comes into play. A strong storyteller can make even the worst data come to life, so imagine how powerful really unique data with a great storyteller could be?

Applying This Principle

For example, the Guardian have been way ahead of the game when it comes to this. A while back they put together an amazing resource of data driven posts on their [Data Blog](#) for the world to see and use. Click on any of the blog posts contained therein for an example of this type of content.



Just one of the graphics on the Guardian Data Blog

Whilst a lot of the items are news related, it does give you a great insight into the potential when it comes to creating data-driven content.

1. What Do You Want To Uncover?

Discovering a unique, uncovered area

The best place to start is to think about the industry you're looking to create this data-driven content for, and establish what has been created before and uncover any niche areas. This will also help you get a better idea of how to actually amass your data. For example, you may be looking into existing mobile phone trends amongst over 50s. If you do a bit of digging, you might find pre-existing research. If you can't, or it's not up-to-date, this could be a great area to revisit and update any research.

Asking The Right Questions

Think about what you want to get from the data. In our example of over 50s mobile phone usage, you might want to get a better idea of the following:

- How often do they use their phones?
- What type of manufacturer do they use?
- How much are they willing to spend per month?
- Do they have a contract or use pay as you go?
- How often do they use the internet?
- How many apps do they download per month?
- What type of apps do they download?

Adding The Right Data-Sets

Once you've thought about the right questions to ask, you'll start to paint a picture of the data sets and subsequent responses. Of course, you'll never know exactly what they'll say, but by thinking about the bigger picture you can start to understand what it is that you'll be getting from your research. For example, the previous questions are centred around the following sets of data:

- Hours per day (phone)
- Manufacturer
- Cost
- Type of mobile phone plan
- Hours per day (internet)
- Number of Apps
- Type of Apps

And once you have your hands on this data, you'll be able to draw correlations between data sets, and answer the following types of questions:

- *Is there a relationship between mobile phone manufacturer and the amount someone over 50 spends on their mobile phone each day?*
- *Do the types of apps used relate to how much money someone over 50 is willing to spend each month?*

As you can see, just by thinking about the industry and the types of findings you want, you'll know exactly what to ask, and how to ask it.

2. Getting Your Data

Good data is not hard to find, you just have to be creative and resourceful. Depending on what type of data-driven content you are looking create, you should consider some of the following methods: (any could be applicable to our over 50s mobile phone example, it just depends what's already out there, as well as your time and resources).

Surveys

Services like [Survey Monkey](#), [YouGov](#) and [OnePoll](#) are excellent at creating surveys to gather data. Some of these services will even have the surveys completed for you as well; however, if you're looking for targeted responses, you're better off hosting a questionnaire or survey on your site instead.



Some of the many excellent survey websites

Questionnaires

Another way is to create a questionnaire and host this in your site. One way of doing this is to have the questionnaire hosted as a blog post, free for your website users to complete. Alternatively, you could host this as a survey for customers to complete after purchasing. By combining this with a prize draw, you'll entice more customers to complete it.

A screenshot of a Facebook post from Koozai dated 14 June. The post asks: 'Happy Friday everyone! Before we break for the weekend what effects have you seen from the latest Penguin update?'. Below the text is a poll with six options, each with a radio button and a count of responses: 'Big decreases' (0), 'Small decreases' (+5), 'No change' (+3), 'Small increases' (+2, selected), 'Big increases' (0), and 'What is the Penguin update?' (+2). Each option is accompanied by a small profile picture of a user who voted.

You can also ask questions on Social media for a quick response

Public Data

Generating unique data is the best way to create really unique content, and to save time there are resources of public data for your use. For example, there are a number of Market Research companies ([Ipsos MORI](#) for example) and Think Tanks across a number of different sectors, which provide a rich source of insightful data. Google even release some of their own data with [Google Consumer Surveys](#), where you can also create surveys too.

Other resources

There are so many places to find data, all thanks to the Internet. Simply type into Google:

- "[Keyword] market research"
- "[Keyword] consumer research"
- "[Keyword] data sets"
- Or use [GapMinder](#), and other sites of this ilk.

3. How To Analyse Your Data

This is worthy of a whitepaper in itself. Analysing data is an art and science, with the goal being to find any trends and insights hidden amongst all that raw data. You just need the right tools and skills to be able to extrapolate that data and draw up correlations. Excel is an excellent tool to use. Using commands like VLOOKUP, as well as Pivot tables you'll be able to make correlations between data sets.

4. Presenting Your Data and Storytelling

The way in which you visualise your data is key. We highly recommend using the expertise of a developer or designer, but if you don't have access to this, use some of the following visualisation tools:

[Google Fusion Tables](#)

[ChartsBin](#)

[iCharts](#)

[Piktochart](#)

Jon Cooper over at Point Blank SEO has devised this [extensive list](#) of data visualisation tools.

Visualising your data is one thing, but creating well written content around it is something else. It's all well and good giving your audience graphs and tables to read, but if you add content to it, it'll make those facts and figures come to life. This is where good storytelling is key. Let's look at some examples.

Whilst Ok Cupid is a bit of an overused example, there is a reason for this; they got their Content Marketing totally spot-on. Take [this blog post](#) about the best questions for a first date as an example. From the data that Ok Cupid receives from its customers, they are able to tell us some really interesting insights. But they don't just present us with raw data; no, they frame it in such a way as to make it incredibly useful. This will take a bit of imagination, creativity, and a fair bit of head scratching to calculate, but by doing so, you'll be able to provide your reader with something they wouldn't have necessarily seen anywhere before.

If we take our Mobile phone usage for the over 50s as an example, from the data we collated, we could potentially have really unique, compelling, sharable content. For example, from the correlations we wanted to figure out, we could potentially see the following titles for our content:

Is there a relationship between mobile phone manufacturer and the amount someone over 50 spends on their mobile phone each day? **"Grey Phone: iPhone is most popular smartphone for over 50s"**

Do the types of apps used relate to how much money someone over 50 is willing to spend each month? **"Travel apps most popular amongst wealthy over 50s"**

It is also recommended to make the data available, to add validity to your content. However, this is entirely up to you and your client.

5. Make sure it gets seen

Here are a few specific examples for data driven content:

- If you've used someone else's data, tell them, show them what you've created using it and ask them to promote it using their social media channels, or even link to it on the website
- Outreach to bloggers / journalists with exclusive insights into your niche area
- Present your findings in a way that'll attract the attention of specific industries, companies, demographics etc.

If we go back to our mobile phone example, from our findings it's possible to outreach to tech bloggers, tabloid journalists, as well as over 50 specific sites and organisations with our content and findings. Ask them to promote your content on their sites, blogs, social media sites and so on.

The Writing Process

Common Copywriting Mistakes

You don't have to search for too long before coming across a piece of content that has been badly written. You know the ones; too much or too little content, mistakes everywhere, and a severe lack of punch. This isn't helping your content whatsoever, so here's what you need to focus on to avoid a major copywriting fail.

Spelling, Grammar And Punctuation

This is the first and most fundamental part of your website copy that you need to consider. Whether you're rewriting your site, or simply want to go through your existing copy, make sure you check there are no spelling and grammar mistakes, nor any punctuation errors for that matter. Some classic spelling mistakes include the irregular use of 'to' and 'too', 'there' and 'their', 'lose' and 'loose'. Then there are the classic punctuation errors such as the irregular use of apostrophes such as 'it's' and 'its', and 'your' and 'you're'. Be sure to have someone read through, and painstakingly check that every line is error free.

Unnecessary Waffle And Jargon

Remember that when someone visits your site, they may not necessarily know exactly what you do, so before you go in with a load of technical jargon that only your colleagues will understand, be sure to write with your audience in mind. Likewise, when you waffle and skirt around the issue, your audience will get bored. It will waste their time and give them a sure-fire reason to leave your site. So you need to find a happy medium. Look to be direct with your copy, but don't go all guns blazing with clichés, jargon and buzz-words.

Focussing On Yourself And Not Your Audience

Copy that isn't reader focused or user centric will fade pretty quickly. In this sense, instead of constantly saying 'we', 'we at...', and 'here we are...', change the focus towards your reader, and what's in it for them. For example, 'you', 'you'll', 'you're'. You need to engage your audience, and this is more achievable if the focus of your attention is actually on your readers, and not how great the company is.

No Structure

Every single piece that you write should have a clear structure and flow to it. Before you begin to write, think to yourself, what do you want the reader to think or do as a result of reading your article?

Your entire piece of content should be formed around one single, simple to understand concept that can be summed up in the shortest amount of words possible. For example:

"Harry Potter is about a boy who discovers he is a wizard and goes to a magical school to learn about it."

"[This Wired article](#) is an epic look at why passwords suck."

"Our [AdWords Beginners Guide](#) is about how to use AdWords if you are new to it."

Once you have a goal, use that to inform the structure; first, look to introduce the topic. Then you want to present the reader with a series of problems, issues and circumstances with which they may be familiar. This will get them thinking. Finally, highlight your solution, and how this will help the reader.

No Call-To-Action

If you don't end with a call-to-action then you really are wasting an opportunity. This could be an option to sign up for a mailing list, to share the content on social media or find out more about your products and services. Find a way to continue the conversation that is logical to the topic and you'll find the best response.



On Koozai.com we end almost every blog post with a relevant whitepaper

Plan Everything Out

You can now go back to your content plan and start to expand the concept out. First of all consider the medium you are writing and the expected length. If it's a book then you'll be writing around 250 words per page (so a 300 page book would be 75,000 words).

For a whitepaper you may only need 25 pages and can use large images too so there's even less words. If it's a guest post, ask the owner how many words they would like. All of this will help you plan how much content you need and how you'll fill it.

Next you'll need to plan everything out. For example with this whitepaper we wrote down a list of core areas we wanted to cover. Then we wrote bullet points of how we would deliver the required information in each core area. You'll see that structure in the headings and subheadings throughout.

Finally we expanded each section into a few paragraphs to explore the topic. This also made the writing process easier as our two authors were able to split the work between them and do it in smaller chunks, talking a section at a time.

Search Engine Optimisation

The old approach to SEO for content has changed quite a lot as a result of the Panda update, and other Google updates and is no longer just about the use of keywords in content.

However, it would be foolish to assume that SEO does not play a role at all in the creation of content and some of the key things you need to do are:

- Include your keyword in the title
- Include your keyword at least twice in the content
- Add an Alt tag to all images
- Include a friendly URL structure (e.g. /top-seo-tips)
- Add the article to a category
- Link to at least one other article you have written (this is handy if other sites steal your content)
- Include a Meta title and Meta description
- Include rel="author" tags (see "Authorship" for more information)
- Make blog posts around 750 words or more
- Don't link off to irrelevant content
- Include header tags
- If using WordPress, implement and configure "WordPress SEO"

Start Writing

Have A Regular Timeslot

If possible you should try and write something every day or at the very least read back your previous day's content. [There's a great post here](#) that explains how to write 5,000 words a day and although that's a bit optimistic for most you can scale that down to a level that works for you.

For our Whitepapers we take around two full days (16 hours of writing) so it's certainly possible to write long meaty content in a shorter time frame.

If you are writing a long blog post or piece of journalism you may have an even tighter deadline so that will dictate some of the time you need (more on deadlines later). The important thing is to block out the time for creating content and stick to it.

Write Slower And Write Better

The other problem with saying “today I’m going to write 5,000 words” is that in reality, writing isn’t like that. Sometimes you’ll be writing a piece you are really knowledgeable on that flows. Those days are great and you’ll nail your word count but not every day will be like that.

Eventually you’ll get to a point and you’ll have to write something that requires a lot of thought. In these cases you will not feel like a writing machine. In fact you’ll probably feel like an awful writer, but that’s ok. It’s better to research a topic fully, call the client for advice or even just step away to think about something else, than to keep making content if you aren’t 100% comfortable with what you are creating.

Expect Everything To Change

Unless you are a psychic or very good at planning, it’s highly likely that once you start creating you’ll need to make changes. That’s ok. It’s natural. It’s healthy. It’ll make your content better. You are trying to turn a few notes on a content plan into something great and it’s only natural that some of the things you write at the start will either a) take you down a different path or b) contradict things you want to say later.

Sometimes the art of creating leads you down a different path than you expected and your brain comes up with opportunities in content that you could never have anticipated. As long as everything you make feels logical and natural to what preceded it then your content will still stand tall and you shouldn’t be afraid to navigate down these paths.

In a [great talk by Vincent Franklin](#) at [Quiet Room](#) he explained how Romeo and Juliet’s plot works because everything that happens is a logical step due to what happened before. The story is really just a sequence of misunderstandings, but it works because they happen in a logical way:

Structure ideas with story spines

Once upon a time... there were two families that hated each other
Every day they met in the street, and fought and argued
Until one day the son of one family gate-crashed a party at the other family’s house
And because of that he danced with their daughter
And because of that they fell in love
And because of that he wanted to stop the fighting
And because of that his best friend got killed
Until finally their parents broke into the tomb and found the bodies of their dead children
And as a result they decided to put aside their differences and live in harmony

Story spines help make content logical and easy to follow



Using this structure and not being afraid to change the content for more logical outcomes is a fantastic approach. Even if you are not telling a fiction story this approach can still work (and no you don't have to start with "once upon a time").

Research Everything

Everything you write has to be accurate and it's also recommended you put a publication date on it or keep it up to date. Even a tiny bit of bad information can sour the entire piece of content and if people start spreading around your errors – or putting them in reviews it can taint your downloads/ sales. That's why we made a 2nd edition of our [Local SEO whitepaper](#) the second we spotted it was out of date.

Expect Deadlines To Change

Let's say your content creation is going well, but you realise you need to write more pages and you only have a week before the deadline you set. What do you do? Do you rush the final part to reach the deadline or do you push the live date back?

First of all, it is recommended you aim to finish content far before the deadline. This gives the content time to breathe if you need to add anything extra. You can't suddenly stop writing without covering all the bases of your topic in enough depth. Hopefully the plan you made at the start will allow you the time you need but you may find you need more space to explain the topic and therefore you have to allow for this. Unless you are making a print book at a set length or need to stick to a set number of words then give your content the right length it needs.

Use of Images

It's important to use images with content, but vital to remember that if you didn't create the image then it's not yours to use unless you have permission, plain and simple. Just like the content you are in the process of creating, someone has spent time and effort creating and publishing that image you want to use. Like all other forms of content, images are protected by copyright laws. The law states that the only way you can use an image is if you own it (you took the photo or bought the rights), you have a licence to use it or if it's fair use.

The law surrounding copyright and the use of images online is incredibly dangerous territory; you certainly can't just perform a quick image search and use the first picture you find. You've got to abide by the law and use royalty free imagery if you don't already own the licences for any photos. Even then you'll still have to accredit the source from which you acquired the photo.

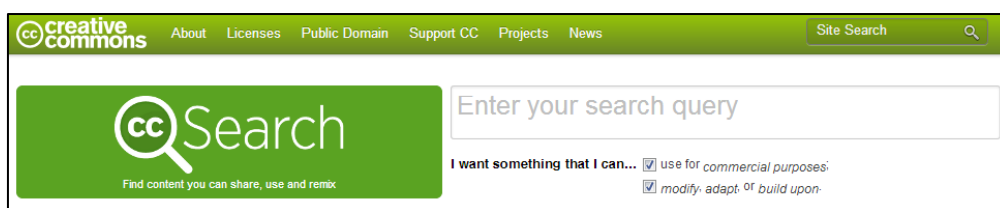
Things can get real confusing quickly, but to be on the safe side you should always make sure you have permission to use the images before you put them in your content. For more information, check out this incredibly helpful article by [Rachel Boothroyd](#).

Image Resources

So, if you can't just copy and paste your images from Google, where can you get them? You can always purchase your images. There are plenty of high quality online image services available. Sites like [BigStock Photo](#) for example have an extensive library of high quality photos, with a range of different pricing packages available.

If you're strapped for cash, or don't want to pay out for a picture, then there are also plenty of free image services, which have tons of royalty free images for which you are unrestricted to use as long as you give credit to their source.

- [Creative Commons](#) have a fantastic search engine which you can use to find royalty free content from across the web.
- [Smart Photo Stock](#) is a collection of royalty free images for bloggers by bloggers. Created by the brilliant [My Blog Guest](#) team, their photo library is constantly growing.
- Get a camera and go take the pictures yourself! The simplest and often best method of getting that photo you're looking for is to go take it yourself.



Creative Commons search is by far one of the easiest ways to find safe images

The Approval / Proofing Process

After your content is created, it must go through a proofreading and approval process. Before it is sent for approval, it must be proofread. If you do not have a thorough proofreading process, your content could potentially be sent out with typos, grammatical errors, the wrong meaning, factually inaccurate information and much more.

Before sending content to be proofed, ensure that you have checked it a number of times yourself. It is always better to revisit content a day or so after it was created. A fresh pair of eyes may uncover minor errors that you'd have been oblivious to had you scanned it straight after creating it.

It is always advised to then have your content double-checked. This could be done by an editor, sub-editor, head of department, whoever; you need to have some sort of gatekeeper to ensure a thorough proofreading process.

It should be noted that proofreading and editing are two very different processes. Editing looks at the way the piece is structured, to ensure the meaning is conveyed clearly and logically. Proofreading is really the very last port of call which involves checking the finer details to detect errors in spelling, punctuation, grammar and format. Whether you split



these processes into two depends on your internal company structure. Alternatively, both processes can be combined, but this may hinder the effectiveness of your proofreading.

With this in mind, there are a number of factors to consider when editing/proofreading. Whether it's your own work or others', consider the following tips:

Title

Does it work? Is it punchy enough? Does it fit the piece itself? Consider what was mentioned prior about creating titles – if the title ticks all of these boxes that's great, if not, it is worth revising.

Introduction

The introduction to any piece of content is the most important. This will be the difference between engaging your audience and letting them switch off, or worse still, hitting exit. [Copyblogger](#) has some great tips on how to master an introduction.

Structure

Is the meaning of the piece clearly conveyed? If not, look at how the piece is structured. Is there a clear beginning, middle and end? You need to make sure it clearly articulates a message, if not, it simply won't work.

Style

Make sure the writing style is correct. Consider yourself as the audience, if you're bored, they'll be bored, so ensure the style works. Also, consider the objective of the piece. What was it supposed to do? Compare this to the style in which it is written. If it falls short, explain why and send back.

Spelling

One of the most fundamental aspects is to ensure there are no spelling errors or typos. Don't just look for a squiggly red line in Word, some words appear to be correct but in context they don't work. So keep your eyes peeled.

Grammar And Punctuation

Look out for the correct use of tenses, misuse of punctuation such as apostrophes, as well as words that sound similar but are spelled differently, e.g. they're, there and their.

Repetitiveness

Whether it's one particular word, a phrase, sentence or message – make sure there is no repetition. This shows a lack of creativity, imagination, structure and ability to write, so it should not exist anywhere in your content.

Relevancy And Accuracy

Finally, is the information contained actually relevant to the piece, or indeed accurate? Always think back to your objective, the title and the meaning of the piece, if something doesn't fit, take it out. In addition, make sure you double check all facts and claims.

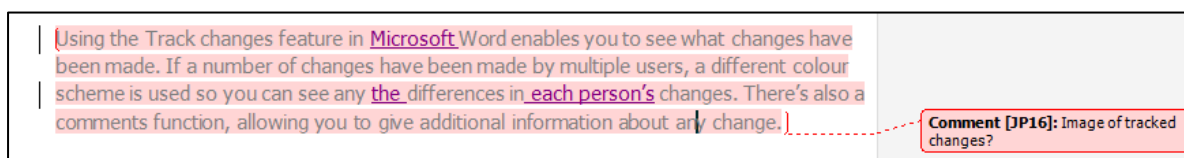
For more information on editing and approval, the [Oxford Learning Institute](#) has published a useful guide.

Cross Collaboration

When working on large projects that involve a number of approval points and sign-offs, you'll want to be able to see who has changed what, or suggested what. This will make the process much easier when receiving content back.

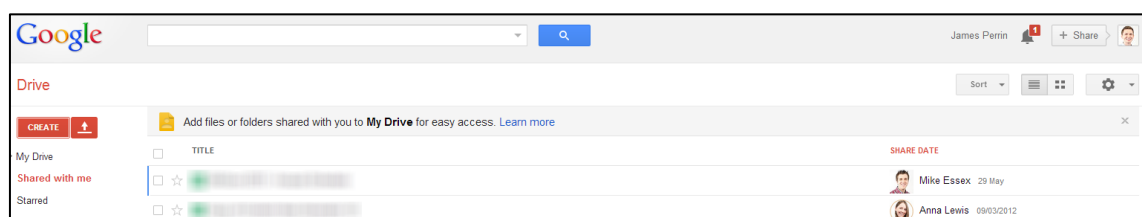
With this in mind, there are a number of ways this can be achieved.

Using the 'Track Changes' feature in Microsoft Word enables you to see what changes have been made. If a number of changes have been made by multiple users, a different colour scheme is used so you can see any the differences in each person's changes. There's also a comments function, allowing you to give additional information about any change.



Here's how the above paragraph looked whilst we proofed it.

Google Docs allows you to easily share documents, spreadsheets, presentations and much more. This is really handy if you're cross collaborating with other writers all over the country, or even the world.



Google docs is an incredibly easy way to share content



Similarly, services like DropBox pretty much do the same. Only with DropBox you can still create, edit and share Microsoft Word documents and you can use DropBox as an online storage space you share with others.

The Launch Process

Once your content is live the work does not end there and ensuring that it gets found and shared becomes the top priority. In the 'preparation' section we looked at ways to prepare your content so you have many outlets for sharing and now you should ensure you:

- Add it to your business Social Media platforms
- Target a specific audience and key individuals (as discovered during your content audit)
- Share it via your employee profiles
- Add it to the author's Google+ page
- Thank people who share your content on social media
- Email it to your subscribers
- Output it via your RSS feeds
- Notify anyone / any companies in the post they have been included

There are also a few more tricks you can use to ensure the post does well, which we'll cover now:

Comments

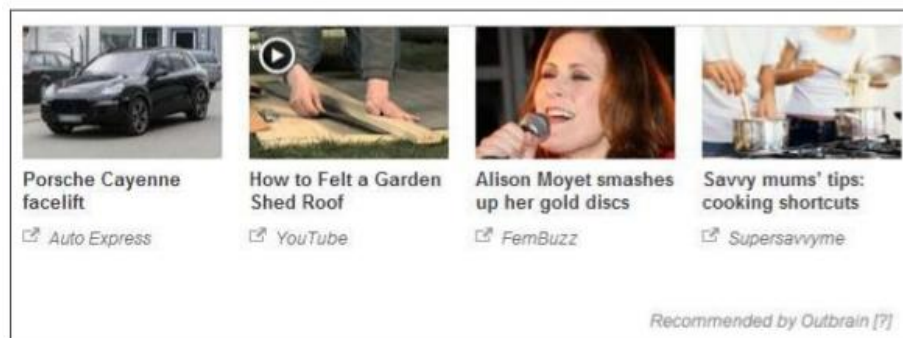
By allowing comments on your content you ensure that you give people an outlet to discuss the topic further. This can be incredibly useful as it allows people to confirm if they agree or disagree with what you have created and this in turn can help shape future pieces that you write.

You can also use this as an opportunity to build up new friendships by interacting with the people who commented. You can do this either on the blog post or by emailing them if they left this information when they added a comment. Either way it will allow you to potentially build a longer term connection that encourages them to come back next time you write something.

In many cases we have seen comment sections include more content than the original piece and this means from a search engine point of view there is a lot of information for them to index which can help the content rank higher. For readers a good debate can be incredibly healthy and can keep an old article continually generating traffic from people who come back to continue a discussion.

Paid Promotion

Many businesses do not have existing social media profiles, email lists or industry friendships so just how can they get their content shared? The simplest option is that they can pay for people to view their content initially in the hope it generates further interest. For example for an average price of £0.10 per click you can get your content seen on The Guardian, Fast Company, Sky News, CNN, TIME and more thanks to [OutBrain](#). You simply choose the content you want promoted and then via "around the web" boxes they show links to your content on related articles:



An example OutBrain content box

These links cannot be indexed by Google so are not for SEO purposes but can be used to help give your content the initial boost it needs to draw links and social shares of its own.

We also recommend [Zemanta](#) who offer a similar system that lets 140,000 bloggers see your content when they are writing blog posts of their own. If they like your content they can include it in their posts, with quality and indexable links which can help generate traffic. Best of all you only pay if a blogger includes your post.

The third site we recommend is [StumbleUpon Paid Discovery](#) who have a slightly different business model. In their case you pay to be seen by users who are looking for new content. If they like what you have written they give it a thumbs up and you get shown more often, this time for free. If they hate it, they move on and you don't get any free views. It's a gamble, but one that paid off for [Hypetree](#) who paid \$125 and got over 182,000 views of their website thanks to a lot of free views.

There are many more channels, including Google AdWords and Facebook advertising, which are explored in [this slide deck](#).

Performance Review

Once your content is live you should compare the results you achieved to your original plan and consider if you reached the right people and achieved the goal.

Go back to your goals and objectives and measure your Content Marketing against these metrics. For example, in terms of goals, did your content:

- Deliver traffic
- Build links
- Increase social shares
- Enhance brand awareness
- Gain business leads
- Contribute to sales

In terms of objectives, did it get the intended response? Remember, you wanted one piece to either:

- Entertain
- Inform
- Teach
- Inspire
- Persuade
- Reveal
- Share insights
- Be controversial
- Create a conversation
- Create a debate

Did your content achieve this? If you feel you didn't get everything right then you can use the research to learn lessons for the next content piece and to scrap ideas that don't work in your niche. We'd also recommend reading up on [Conversion Rate Optimisation](#) to look at ways to make your content generate more leads and better achieve your business goals.

Repurposing Content

Just because you've created content on a topic once it doesn't mean you can never examine that same area again on your own blog or on others. Here are some of the best ways of ensuring you get the most out of every idea:

- Create a video about a blog post idea
- Turn Infographics into presentations and add them to SlideShare
- Produce a webinar and live stream it on Google+
- Read the comments on your posts and answer questions in a follow-up
- Write a follow-up post (e.g. Ten more examples of...)
- Create a guest post that exposes the topic to a new audience

Summary

Thank you for reading our whitepaper on Content Marketing. In the spirit of creating great content, it's the most detailed single piece of content we have been involved in as we felt that was the best way to do the topic justice.

We wanted to cover everything someone would need from start to finish and to not leave anything out so we hope this has covered all of your questions and much more.

You can find out more about what we do by following our profiles below and we wish you the best of luck with any content you create.



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sales@koozai.com

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/koozai